

**THE IMPLEMENTATION OF THE REGULATORY FUNCTIONS OF THE
PHARMACIST'S COUNCIL OF NIGERIA (PCN) IN RESPECT OF EDUCATION AND
CONTINUING PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT (CPD) PROGRAMMES**

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PREAMBLE

The Pharmacists Council of Nigeria (PCN) is a Federal Government agency established by Act CAP P17, LFN 2004. It is mandated to regulate all aspects of pharmacy education, training, and practice in Nigeria.

The pharmacy profession in Nigeria comprises two cadres:

- **Pharmacists**
- **Pharmacy Technicians**

Pharmacists are trained in approved universities for a minimum of five years (B.Pharm) or six years (Pharm.D). Pharmacy Technicians are trained in colleges or schools of health technology for a minimum of three years to become certified.

The key regulatory functions of the PCN in education and training include:

- Determining the standard of knowledge and skills required to become a pharmacist or pharmacy technician in Nigeria.
- Approving institutions in Nigeria permitted to train pharmacists and pharmacy technicians.
- Recognizing qualifications granted by foreign institutions for the purpose of practice in Nigeria.

This paper outlines the PCN's responsibilities in the following areas:

1. Pharmacy Education and Continuing Professional Development (CPD)
2. Pharmacy Technician (PT) Education
3. Training of Patent and Proprietary Medicine Vendors License (PPMVL) Holders

1.0 PCN RESPONSIBILITIES: PHARMACY EDUCATION & CONTINUING PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT (CPD)

1.1 Benchmark Minimum Academic Standard (BMAS): The PCN is responsible for establishing the Minimum Academic Requirements (MAR) for the Bachelor of Pharmacy (B.Pharm) and Doctor of Pharmacy (Pharm.D) degree programs.

- The PCN's Deans Committee prepares the MAR, which is then reviewed by the Education Committee and recommended to the Governing Council for approval.
- Once approved, the MAR is forwarded to the National Universities Commission (NUC) for incorporation into the final BMAS document.
- The approved BMAS is disseminated to all Faculties of Pharmacy/Pharmaceutical Sciences for implementation.
- The BMAS is subject to a mandatory review every five years.

1.2 Accreditation of Pharmacy Schools: The PCN develops and maintains scoring formats to ensure objective and uniform assessment of facilities and human resources during accreditation visits.

- This format is designed to minimize subjective assessment and standardize evaluations across all institutions.
- The scoring format collects data on:
 - **Human Resources:** Academic staff (both professional and non-professional) and non-academic staff (administrative and technical). Professional staff are classified as senior academics (Lecturer I and above).
 - **Facilities:** Buildings, including offices, classrooms, and laboratories.
 - **Teaching Support Facilities:** Library, herbarium, botanical garden, and animal house.
- The Education Committee constitutes accreditation teams and recommends them to the Governing Council for approval.
- The report from each accreditation visit is considered by the Education Committee before a final recommendation is made to the Governing Council.

1.3 Other Key Programmes

The PCN also oversees:

- **Internship Training**

- **Pre-registration Examination for Interns**
- **Foreign Pharmacy Graduate Orientation Program (FPGOP)**
- **Mandatory Continuing Professional Development (MCPD) for Pharmacists**

2.0 PCN RESPONSIBILITIES: PHARMACY TECHNICIAN (PT) EDUCATION

The PCN regulates the training and certification of Pharmacy Technicians through:

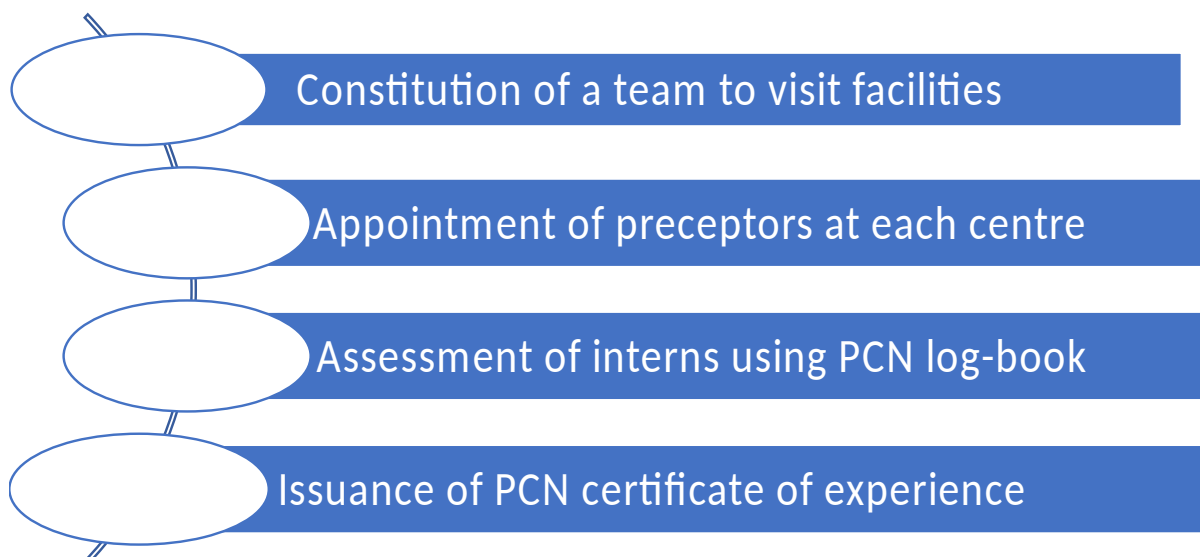
- Accreditation of schools and colleges of health technology offering PT programs.
- Development of the course content for PT education.
- Administration of the National Pre-Certification Examination for PTs.
- Development of CPD program content for licensed PTs.

3.0 PCN RESPONSIBILITIES: TRAINING OF PATENT AND PROPRIETARY MEDICINE VENDORS (PPMVL)

The PCN ensures the competency of PPMVL holders through:

- Developing the course content for the orientation program for new licensees.
- Developing the course content for mandatory refresher training for existing PPMVL holders.

Regulation of Internship training program



1.4 Pre-Registration Examination (PEP)

The Pre-registration Examination (PEP) is a quality assurance mechanism introduced by the PCN to ensure all intern pharmacists meet a consistent national standard before full registration, aligning with global best practices.

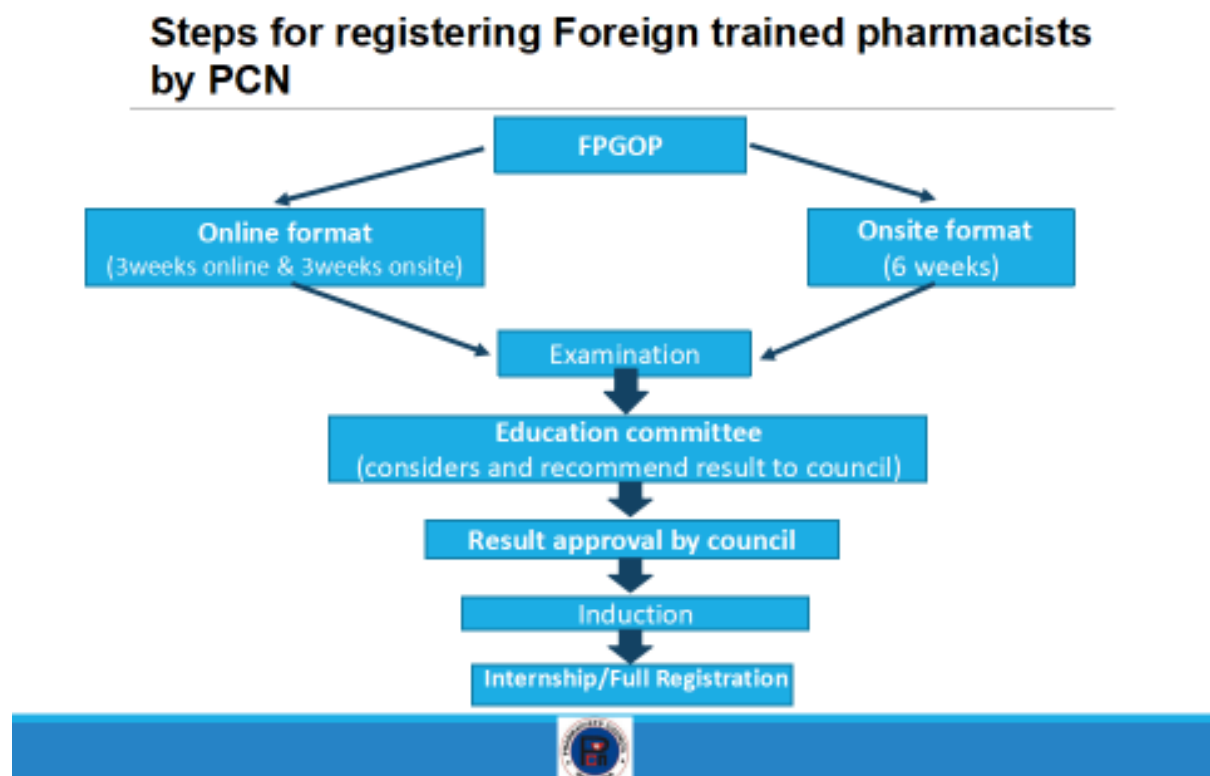
- The PEP was approved by the Governing Council in 2015, with the first examination conducted in October 2017.
- A dedicated committee appointed by the Council sets the examination questions based on the approved curriculum.
- The examination is administered as a computer-based test at designated centers across Nigeria.
- Results are collated and presented to the Governing Council via the Education Committee for final approval.
- Successful candidates are eligible to be registered as pharmacists to practice in Nigeria.

1.5 Foreign Pharmacy Graduate Orientation Program (FPGOP)

The FPGOP is designed for Nigerian pharmacists trained in foreign universities who wish to be registered to practice in Nigeria.

- The PCN is responsible for developing the course content and administering this program.

- The program assesses the competencies of foreign-trained graduates and orients them to the Nigerian healthcare context and legal framework.



1.6 Mandatory Continuing Professional Development (MCPD) for Pharmacists

The PCN holds full responsibility for administering the Mandatory Continuing Professional Development (MCPD) program to ensure pharmacists maintain and enhance their competencies throughout their careers. Key activities include:

- Developing and periodically reviewing the MCPD modular system.
- Designing MCPD courses, curricula, and modules that address contemporary advancements in pharmacy practice.
- Accrediting MCPD provider centers nationwide.
- Developing course content and allocating credit points for various activities, including face-to-face and online conferences, workshops, and seminars.

- Implementing and managing an online MCPD platform for streamlined record-keeping and accessibility.
- Allocating credit points to pharmacists who successfully complete MCPD programs.

2.0 PCN RESPONSIBILITIES: PHARMACY TECHNICIAN (PT) EDUCATION & DEVELOPMENT

2.1 PT Training Curriculum: The Pharmacy Technician (PT) is a middle-level cadre within the pharmacy profession.

- The PCN's Governing Council approves the 3-year training curriculum delivered at accredited Colleges/Schools of Health Technology.
- The PCN Training Sub-Committee is responsible for curriculum development, which covers basic sciences, principles of PT practice, basic dispensing, pharmacology, primary healthcare, anatomy, and physiology.
- The program includes a mandatory minimum of six months of experiential learning in hospitals and community pharmacies.

2.2 National Pre-Certification Examination: The PCN administers the National Pre-Certification Examination for Pharmacy Technicians.

- The examination is held annually. Eligibility requires graduation from a PCN-accredited College of Health Technology.
- An Ad-hoc Committee, constituted by the PCN Training Committee from Heads of Department of approved colleges, sets the examination questions.
- The PCN administers the exam, and the Ad-hoc Committee moderates the results.
- Results are recommended to the Governing Council via the Education Committee for approval before release to candidates through their colleges.
- Successful candidates are inducted as Certified Pharmacy Technicians in Nigeria.

- Foreign-trained Pharmacy Technicians must undergo certificate evaluation before being eligible to sit for the national examination.

2.3 Continuing Professional Development (CPD) for Pharmacy Technicians

- The PCN develops the course content for CPD programs for licensed Pharmacy Technicians.
- The Council is currently reviewing the MCPD guidelines for PTs, which includes developing new manuals, facilitator guides, and presentation slides.

3.0 PCN RESPONSIBILITIES: TRAINING OF PATENT AND PROPRIETARY MEDICINE VENDORS (PPMVL)

The PCN, as the licensing authority, is responsible for educating PPMVL holders to ensure the safe and legal sale of patent medicines. This involves:

- **Orientation for New Licensees:** Developing course content for mandatory orientation programs, covering:
 - Legal and regulatory frameworks governing the sale of patent medicines.
 - Operational responsibilities of vendors.
 - Elementary aspects of product procurement and handling.
 - The approved patent medicine list.
- **Continuing Education:** Organizing refresher training and Continuing Education Programs (CEP) for existing licensees.
- **Resource Development:** Preparing and updating manuals for both orientation and continuing education programs.